

submission, and revolted from Darius, but were defeated in battle, and again reduced to subjection.¹ Now, however, in the time of Astyages, it was the Persians who under Cyrus revolted from the Medes, and became thenceforth the rulers of Asia. Cyrus kept Astyages at his court during the remainder of his life, without doing him any further injury. Such then were the circumstances of the birth and bringing up of Cyrus, and such were the steps by which he mounted the throne. It was at a later date that he was attacked by Croesus, and overthrew him, as I have related in an earlier portion of this history. The overthrow of Croesus made him master of the whole of Asia.

131. The customs which I know the Persians to observe are the following. They have no images of the gods, no temples nor altars, and consider the use of them a sign of folly.²

Dr. Brandis, pp. 6-8.) This would make their rule begin in the twenty-third year of Darius.

Niebuhr (Denkschrift d. Berl. Ac. d. Wissenschaft, 1820-1, pp. 49-50) suspected that the passage was corrupt, and proposed the following reading—*ἄρξαντες τῆς ἀγῶν Ἀλφειοῦ ποταμοῦ Ἀσίης ἐπὶ ἔτεα πεντήκοντα καὶ ἑκατὸν, παρὲς ἣ ὅσον οἱ Σκύθαι ἤρχον, τριήκοντα δυνάμειοντα*. This would remove some, but not all, of the difficulties. It is moreover too extensive an alteration to be received against the authority of all the MSS.

¹ It has been usual to regard this outbreak as identical with the revolt recorded by Xenophon (Hell. i. ii. ad fin.) in almost the same words. Bähr (in loc.) and Dahlmann (Life of Herod. p. 33, Engl. Tr.) have argued from the passage that Herodotus was still employed upon his history as late as B. C. 407. Clinton is of the same opinion, except that he places the revolt one year earlier (F. H. vol. ii. p. 87. Ol. 92, 4). Mr. Grote, with his usual sagacity, perceived that Herodotus could not intend a revolt 150 years after the subjection, or mean by Darius "without any adjective designation," any other Darius than the son of Hystaspes. He saw, therefore, that there must have been a revolt of the Medes from Darius Hystaspes, of which this passage was possibly the only record (Hist. of Greece, vol. iv. p. 304, note). Apparently he was not aware of the great inscription of Darius at Behistun, which had been published by Col. Rawlinson the year before his fourth volume appeared, wherein a long and elaborate account is given of a Median revolt which occurred in the third year of the reign of Darius, and was put down with difficulty. Col. Rawlinson gives the general outline of the struggle as follows:—

"A civil war of a far more formidable character broke out to the northward. Media, Assyria, and Armenia, appear to have been confederated in a bold attempt to recover their independence. They elevated to the throne a descendant, real or supposed, of the ancient line of [Median] kings; and after six actions had been fought between the partisans of this powerful chief and the troops which were employed by Darius, under the command of three of his most distinguished generals, unfavourably it must be presumed to the latter, or at any rate with a very partial and equivocal success, the monarch found himself compelled to repair in person to the scene of conflict. Darius accordingly, in the third year of his reign, re-ascended from Babylon to Media. He brought his enemy to action without delay, defeated and pursued him, and taking him prisoner at Rhages, he slew him in the citadel of Ecbatana" (Behist. Inscript. vol. i. pp. 188-9).

Col. Mure, I observe, though aware of this discovery, maintains the view of Bähr and Dahlmann (Literature of Greece, vol. iv. App. G.), but not, I think, successfully.

² On the general subject of the religion of the Persians, see the Essays appended to this volume, Essay v.